

PEOPLE

Research Reports

Hippocrates, Epid. 5: 86, an Ancient ‘Simple’ Story from Antiquity? – A Comparative and Contextual Folkloric Approach

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A short, problematic and seldom discussed passage to be found in one Hippocratic text gives us a chance to discuss some aspects of folklore in Ancient Greece. A comparative and contextual folkloric approach to the text in question, in fact, reveals that the passage constitutes what is possibly one of the earliest variants of the well-known narrative and experiential theme of a snake or other similar

small animal entering the human body (e.g. motif B784; tale-type AaTh/ATU 285B*). This was already perfectly understood by Renaissance commentators, students and interpreters of Hippocrates. This paper aims to throw light on this ancient textual source through a combination of folklore and philological analysis, also in the light of modern and contemporary interpretations.

Degrees of Well-Formedness: The Formula Principle in the Analysis of Oral-Poetic Meters

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This paper presents an argument that the value of formulaic language is qualitatively different from other verbalization in the metrical analysis of oral poetry. This is a three-part argument:

1. Formulaic language in oral poetry develops in relation to the metrical environments of the poetic system in which it is realized.
2. Metrical well-formedness in oral poetry is a perceived quality of text that can vary by degree in ‘better’ or ‘worse’ lines rather than being assessed in terms of absolute binary categories of ‘metrically well-formed’ versus ‘not metrically well-formed’.
3. If points (1) and (2) are accepted, it follows that metrically entangled formulae are more *likely to reflect metrically ‘better’ lines* – what I call the Formula Principle.

Formulaic language is a broad linguistic category (see Wray 2002), and a wide range of formulaic language can be realized in an oral poetic tradition. The Formula Principle is

concerned with ‘metrically entangled’ expressions as units of utterance or integers of a poetic lexicon that have become historically linked to particular metrical environments. Linkages between oral-poetic formulae and meter have long been recognized: this is the foundation of Oral-Formulaic Theory (cf. Parry 1928; Lord 1960). I take a usage-based approach to oral-poetic systems. Oral-poetic meters can be abstracted in analysis, but they are inevitably realized and communicated through language by embodied individuals in situated social activity. An oral-poetic linguistic register (i.e. language as used in the poetry) thus develops in a “symbiotic” relation to meter through social practice (Foley 1996). Consequently the precise degrees and varieties of flexibility that formulaic language evolves will be tradition-dependent (see e.g. Foley 1990), but that evolution will nonetheless be interfaced with

the metrical environment in which poetic discourse is verbalized.

Approaching oral poetry as a form of language practice requires recognizing that oral-poetic meter is assessed and communicated ‘by ear’. A working hypothesis follows that metrical well-formedness is perceived like grammatical correctness: although many variations may be classed as ‘correct’ versus ‘incorrect’, many simply sound ‘better’ or ‘worse’ – and in practice, many little things simply go unnoticed in the flow of language. It is customary to abstract a meter analytically as an ideal and absolute model and assess expressions as either well-formed or not in relation to that model. The present approach suggests that meters are characterized by sets of conventions interfaced with one or more modes of expression (on which, see Frog 2012: 52–54) and that individual conventions are opened to varying degrees of flexibility in relation to one another. Without denying that some lines may be considered metrically ‘bad’, approaching metrical well-formedness as a perceived quality of text allows it to be viewed in terms of varying degrees within the grey area of ‘sounding right’ within the flow of performance.

The hypothesis that well-formedness may be a matter of degree is supported by the corpus of kalevalaic epic. Kalevala-meter is an alliterative trochaic tetrameter with rules governing the placement of long and short syllables. The syllable-based rhythm resists variations perceivable as disrupting the rhythm of the mode of expression, whereas formulaic lines that are metrically less well-formed in terms of alliteration or the placement of long and short syllables can become socially established. However, these variations are managed through social practice and better-formed lines exhibit wider social circulation and significantly greater long-term stability.

Two complicating factors in particular require mention. First, expressions that are less well-formed metrically may find a degree of social sustainability through less conventional means of integration into the flow of text. This may occur internally to a line, such as through alliteration on metrically stressed rather than lexically stressed

positions (e.g. *vuorehen teräsperähän* [‘into a steel-bottomed mountain’]). Also, metrically weaker lines may be ‘suspended’ in a larger textual unit such as a couplet united by parallel alliteration (e.g. *Tuonen mustahan jokehen, / Manalan ikipurohon* [‘into Death’s black river / Death-land’s eternal stream’]) or in a textual sequence within which e.g. other forms of parallelism create text cohesion. Formulaic language may therefore be maintained as ‘sounding right’ owing to additional factors than that it converges with ideals of metrical well-formedness.

Second, formulaic expressions may become highly crystallized or advance to lexicalization while conventions of the poetry change around it. Consequently, formulaic language may reflect ideals of metricity from an earlier period. This happened in kalevalaic epic traditions where established formulaic expressions were maintained while the conventions for producing new lines were formed on the basis of slightly different standards (Tarkka 2013: 527n.356). The crystallization of formulaic expressions into extremely fixed forms may also lead them to become metrically ‘worse’ lines owing to phonetic changes in the meter (e.g. Leino 2002: 224). In this case, rather than ‘sounding right’, such expressions might simply be accepted as metrically idiomatic as an integrated part of internalizing the poetic system.¹ In any case, the social sustainability of such expressions in these different types of cases is linked to both the conservatism of the poetic system and the perceivability of their integration into the texture of composition. In general, metrically weaker formulaic expressions appear historically more susceptible to alteration or alternation with metrically ‘better’ alternatives.

The Formula Principle is as follows:

As socially shaped expressions, metrically entangled formulae are more likely to reflect *metrically ‘better’ lines than expressions that are formulated by poets on an individual basis, making such formulae of a qualitatively different value in metrical analysis.*

This principle does not claim that formulaic expressions are necessarily metrically perfect. This approach acknowledges that other (tradition-dependent) factors may affect the

ability for formulaic expressions to ‘sound right’ in the flow of poetic discourse. The qualitative assessment of a formula as reflecting ideals of metricality therefore requires consideration of contextual and historical factors (N.B. – metrical variation could, in theory, function as e.g. a discourse marker). Nevertheless, the more socially established formulaic expressions are, the more probable that they reflect ideals of realizing the meter. In metrical analysis, such formulae are therefore more likely to yield qualitatively better data than lines situationally composed by one individual.

Notes

1. An extreme case of this type of lexical conservatism in the wake of historical change can be observed in lines of Old Norse dróttkvætt poetry in which words that had lost a syllable owing to historical phonetic change were described as ‘slow’ (seinn), presumably because in performance they continued to be maintained rhythmically across two metrical positions (cf. Árnason 1991: 90–91).

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‘Parallelism’ versus ‘Not Parallelism’

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Paper presented at the seminar-workshop *Parallelism in Verbal Art and Performance* organized by Folklore Studies, University of Helsinki, and the Finnish Literature Society, held 26th–27th May 2014 in Helsinki, Finland.

Parallelism is normally conceived of as a phenomenon at the level of language, most often approached in terms of equivalence or contrast between adjacent lines of poetry. This paper returns to the much broader conception of parallelism as conceived by Roman Jakobson, who proposed that “on every level of language the essence of poetic artifice consists in recurrent returns” (Jakobson 1981 [1966]: 98).

‘Parallelism’ is an etic term that functions as a research tool to describe a phenomenon in human expressive behaviours. The broader the range phenomena that this term is used to describe, the more abstract that the tool will become. Any research tool will be better suited to certain materials and research questions than others. As a tool, parallelism can be calibrated to the research material and the questions posed by the researcher. The phenomenon of parallelism appears “under-theorized” (Nigel Fabb, p.c.). My goal in this

paper was to interrogate the abstract phenomenon of human poetic expression.

First, parallelism is not exclusive to poetry. ‘Oral poetry’ can be defined as a conventional system for expression that is aesthetically marked and unambiguously differentiated from conversational speech within a community. Poetics is here conceived in terms of perceivable qualities of text (following Tsur 1992). The differentiation of oral poetry from aesthetically unmarked discourse is realized in part already at the level of elocution, which appears directly connected with making the poetic qualities of a text perceivable. Ethnopoetics (e.g. Hymes 1981) extends the analysis of poetics of discourse from ‘poetry’ as opposed to ‘not poetry’ (e.g. owing to a formalized meter) to forms of discourse that are recognizable and qualitatively evaluable according to its conventional strategies and formal features, whether this is a sermon, lecture, political